



Digvijay Singh

RAVI S SAHNI

"The politics of inclusion is the only way"

DIGVIJAY SINGH FORMER CM, MADHYA PRADESH

A leader must have a heart as well as a head so that he enthuses and inspires the people. He should instil confidence in every section of society. He should practise the politics of inclusion, not of exclusion.

I have never subscribed to the politics of votebanks and in a multi-religious, multi-ethnic, multi-cultural and multi-lingual country like ours, the politics of votebanks has a certain shelf life. But, at the same time, every political party that wants to get a foothold in national politics raises the

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tarazu aur talwar, inko maro jute char (Beat with your shoes those who use the tilak, weighing balance or sword)." coming from others. Once the parties get a foothold, they find that they have reached a threshold, going beyond which will require a more inclusive approach.

The Congress party has often been charged with the appeasement of Muslims. Fundamentalists, whether Hindu or Muslim, work in tandem. We have always fought the fundamentalists. And my party has been charged with minorityism. Well, minorityism is something which is a part of the politics of inclusion. If I am charged with minorityism or appeasement of Muslims, I would gladly accept the charge. Because, after all, every civil society is sensitive to the cause of the minorities. We can't ignore the historical fact that certain sections of society have faced oppression and humiliation for thousands of years. There has to be a level playing field—and that takes time.

We still have large sections of the population who live below the poverty line. We have to provide more funds and pump in more money to bring about the socio-economic development of the deprived classes. At the same time we have to set a new pace for personal and collective achievement. Leadership has to be in line with these challenges. Apart from the usual attributes, leadership now needs a different liberated mindset. The Indian ethos of politics of inclusion can be the only way to end votebank politics in India.

D I S C U S S I O N

Q. I cannot let Digvijay Singh get away with the statement that dynastic rule in India is the same as in America. When was the last time anybody in his party challenged the Gandhi family for leadership and lived to tell the tale? I am not judgmental about it because other parties have dynastic politics but they don't indulge in the hypocrisy of saying we elect our leaders. Having said that, there was a defining political statement made last year—

maut ke saudagar (merchant of death). Now can each of you answer this in one sentence: Was that a statement of votebank politics or a statement challenging votebank politics?

Digvijay: As far as the dynastic rule theory is concerned, we have our elections and why does it affect anyone if we elect Sonia Gandhi as our leader? It is not your concern, it is a concern of our political party. Where ever she has reached, she has reached on the

basis of free and fair elections and was not nominated. As far as the '*maut ka saudagar*' statement is concerned, it was a statement made in Gujarat on the issue of the communal carnage in 2002. I was very amused when Advani replied that Modi cannot be a merchant of death but he can be a Hitler.

Abdullah: I don't remember who said it, but that was a very bad statement because how can Modi be the merchant of death? If he was the merchant of death, I would

have sent him across and said well get on with the job then.

Q. All of you are honest enough to admit there is votebank politics. So will it end soon? Yes or no?

Abdullah: I have to say that it will end soon, but I don't see it.

Digvijay: It can but it will not.

Modi: It is a challenge but we must try our level best.

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